throughs with the ball. But that's a luxury this current Indian team cannot afford, with none of their top-order batters bowling at the international level consistently.

Blame it on the new power-play rules—five fielders inside the 30-yard circle between overs 11 to 40. Introduced in 2015 to rid the format of the 'boring' middle phase, it offers no respite to the bowlers. Combined with another rule change of two new balls from both ends—as opposed to the use of only one ball for the entire 50 overs previously—and the ODI format looks to have changed drastically since 2011. A hard, relatively new ball that comes on to the bat is far more conducive to stroke-play than the worn-out, 40- or 50-overs old ball that is slow off the pitch. The rules have resulted in teams adopting the cavalier batting approach of T20 cricket in ODIs as well, as is reflected in the ever-increasing team totals in the 50-over format. Of the 24 occasions where a 400-plus score has been recorded in ODI cricket, 15 have come since the 2011 World Cup.

Whatever the reasons for the imbalance between the bat and ball, the inflexibility brought on by the lack of genuine all-rounders leaves the Indian XI severely compromised. In a tournament where most top contenders bat as deep as No. 10, India can at best list batters till No. 8 by calling on all-rounders like Shardul, Axar and Ashwin. Then there's the 'fear-of-failure' charge that the team contends with perennially. Its genesis lies in India's apparent inability to bring its A-game on the big day, especially seen in the knockout stages of world cups. Truly world-class teams are known to raise their performance a notch or two on D-days by playing fearlessly. India, on the other hand, has been found out playing percentage (read safe) cricket at the same stage. Is it the expectations of 1.44 billion Indians that weighs them down? "Indians play stats-driven cricket... they are too often, too worried about their stats. They are so scared to take risks, because of what might be said or printed," is how former New Zealand cricketer Simon Doull parsed it during a recent broadcast on Sky Sports. Will this 'enfeeblement' be amplified by the fact that India are the hosts, for it means pressure? And more pressure.

THE HOME ADVANTAGE

Conversely, the 'home advantage' also presents India with its greatest opportunity. The fact that the past three editions have seen the hosts pocket the one-day title tells an important story. Familiarity with the condi-

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



AP

NAJMUL HUSSAIN SHANTO
BANGLADESH
One of the best batting talents in The Tigers team. Started the Asia Cup with two big knocks. A busy batter in the middle-order, Indian conditions will suit him

LIAM LIVINGSTONE
ENGLAND
Livingstone stands out as the X factor for the defending champions. An excellent fielder, he has the power to clear boundaries at will. Is a handy leg-spinner too



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